CSIS AUSTRALIA CHAIR

Australia Daily Brief

Thursday, October 29, 2026

1,515 words · 6 min read

RE: NZ election: National sub-25%, Opportunity surges · SAS Afghanistan inquiry cites command failures · Coalition splits over EU trade deal · Inflation hits 4.3% · Fiji election 'in limbo'

ASX 200	AUD/USD	NZX 50	NZD/USD
8,892	0.7035	13,710	0.5611
+1.12%	+0.21%	-0.37%	-1.30%

IN THIS ISSUE Top Stories · Overnight · Stat · Pacific · New Zealand · Canberra · Markets · Documents · Upcoming · The Wire

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. New Zealand's National Party has dropped below 25 percent in the latest RNZ-Reid Research poll, nine days before the November 7 election, with the Opportunity Party positioned as a potential kingmaker.
2. A declassified inquiry into Australia's Special Air Service Regiment finds systemic cultural failures and an 'inversion of authority' enabled alleged war crimes in Afghanistan, though the ADF chief has reportedly called the matter closed.
3. Coalition unity cracked again this week as Liberal MP Alex Hawke broke ranks over the Nationals' rejection of the EU trade deal, handing Albanese an opening to attack on inflation that hit 4.3 percent in September.

TOP STORIES

NZ-POLITICS

National falls below 25 percent as Opportunity surges nine days from New Zealand's election

New Zealand's National Party has dropped below *25 percent* in the latest RNZ-Reid Research poll, while the Opportunity Party has reached a new high that could make it kingmaker. **Christopher Luxon** posted on social media warning of 'dire consequences' if the poll becomes reality, saying it would produce a Labour-Greens government with Chloe Swarbrick as finance minister. Campaign chair **Simeon Brown** acknowledged to RNZ the November 7 election will be 'very close.'

per RNZ: "Christopher Luxon warns against making latest poll a 'reality'"

AU-DEFENSE

Declassified inquiry finds 'abandonment of curiosity' enabled SAS war crimes culture in Afghanistan

A newly declassified inquiry into Australia's Special Air Service Regiment found deep, systemic cultural problems and an 'inversion of authority' within units that helped enable alleged war crimes during the Afghanistan war. It found senior commanders overlooked warning signs, including a rising number of enemy casualties, amid an absence of effective leadership. The Australian reports the ADF chief has since called the matter 'case closed,' declining further action.

per ABC News: "Inquiry slams culture and command of Australia's SAS during Afghanistan war" · also The Australian: "'Case closed': ADF chief rules out action on SAS command failures"

AU-POLITICS

Coalition splits again over EU trade deal as One Nation's sway grows

A Liberal-only meeting in Canberra this week saw former minister **Alex Hawke**, a factional opponent of leader **Angus Taylor**, speak out against the Nationals' position opposing a proposed Australia-EU free trade deal. Senator **Matt Canavan** had declared, without leadership group approval, that both Coalition parties opposed the deal a fortnight earlier. **Anthony Albanese** has seized on the split to attack the Coalition's economic credibility as inflation rises.

per SMH (Paul Sakkal): "Cracks emerge in reunited Coalition over trade deal and AI" · also SMH: "Albanese bets on trade brawl to bash Coalition amid inflation woes"

AU-DEFENSE

Australia flags concern after China tests ballistic missile from nuclear submarine

Chinese officials contacted Canberra to give advance warning of a ballistic missile test launched from a nuclear-powered submarine, Crikey reported, with Foreign Minister **Penny Wong** in Fiji at the time. Australian officials have since indicated concern about the test without detailing its location or the submarine involved.

per Crikey: "'You can draw the inference': Australia reveals concerns about Chinese ballistic missile test from nuclear sub"

OVERNIGHT

AU-DEFENSE

Union and Viva Energy warn Canberra is 'dangerously unprepared' on fuel · SMH

A union and Viva Energy issued a joint warning to **Anthony Albanese** that decades of industrial decline and reliance on volatile overseas shipping routes have left essential services, freight and farming exposed in the event of international conflict, SMH reported.

AU-POLITICS

Australian parties triple YouTube ad spend as TV campaigning declines · Politico

Australian political parties have tripled their YouTube advertising spend at the expense of television buys, Politico reported, marking a structural shift in how federal campaigns reach voters.

AU-DEFENSE

NT teenager charged with terror offences over 3D-printed gun plans · AFP

A Northern Territory teenager faces terror charges after police seized extremism material and 3D-printed gun schematics, AFP reported, the latest case to draw scrutiny of youth radicalisation since federal police told Senate estimates that 55 radicalised children have come to their attention.

TRADE-ECONOMY

RBA's blunt messaging raises questions about peak in rates · WSJ

The Wall Street Journal reports the Reserve Bank of Australia's increasingly blunt public messaging is fuelling debate over whether its tightening cycle is near a peak, after a hotter-than-expected September inflation print raised the odds of a further rate rise.

TRADE-ECONOMY

Bloomberg: Australia's data centre investment boom faces a reckoning · Bloomberg

Bloomberg opinion examines rising local pushback against data centre construction in Australia, arguing pension-fund financing and community opposition are colliding as the AI infrastructure build-out accelerates nationwide.

STAT OF THE DAY

4.3%

Australia's September quarter headline inflation rate

The hottest inflation reading since March intensifies pressure for a further RBA rate rise and has sharpened the Albanese-Coalition fight over budget savings.

ABC News

PACIFIC WIRE

FIJI · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Fiji's general election, set for February 2027, now 'in limbo'

Fiji's voters face an uncertain timeline after the latest date for a Writ of Election cast the February 2027 general election into doubt, Islands Business reported, amid ongoing constitutional reform debate.

FIJI · FIJIVILLAGE

Civil Society Alliance calls for Fiji constitution vote to be deferred six months

Fiji's Civil Society Alliance for Democracy has called for the planned constitutional vote to be deferred and for six months of further consultation, Fijivillage reported, intensifying pressure on the government's reform timeline.

FIJI · FIJIVILLAGE

Fiji military commander says armed forces must respect democratic choices

Fiji's Republic of Fiji Military Forces commander said the military must respect the people's democratic choices, Fijivillage reported, a notable intervention as the country's election timeline and constitutional reform remain unresolved.

REGIONAL · ABC PACIFIC

Civil society groups push back on Israel's entry to Pacific Islands Forum

The Pacific Islands Forum has welcomed Israel as a sectoral partner to work on water, desalination and climate adaptation, but Pacific civil society groups including the Pacific Network on Globalisation are demanding more transparency over the decision, ABC Pacific reported.

TIMOR-LESTE · ABC PACIFIC

Timor-Leste presses ahead with Greater Sunrise gas project after Woodside exit

Timor-Leste has vowed to continue the Greater Sunrise project after Woodside sold its 33 percent stake for *$285 million*, leaving it without an operator, ABC Pacific reported. Analyst Saul Kavonic warned the government risks wagering its economic future on a project without an experienced operator.

COOK ISLANDS · COOK ISLANDS NEWS

Cook Islands joins new Pacific Community of Policing initiative

Cook Islands Police have joined the newly launched Pacific Community of Policing, a unified regional approach to tackling transnational crime, Cook Islands News reported.

REGIONAL · ISLANDS BUSINESS

West Papua diplomacy ramps up ahead of Forum discussions

West Papua, first placed on a Forum leaders' agenda in Kiribati in 2000, is drawing renewed regional diplomatic attention, Islands Business reported, as the issue remains an ongoing point of contention within the Pacific Islands Forum.

NEW ZEALAND

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ

Peters tells NZ First voters to back National's Bishop in Hutt South

Winston Peters told supporters in Hutt South to vote for National's **Chris Bishop**, warning he could lose his seat otherwise, as NZ First pursues an 'overhang' strategy to maximise seats ahead of the November 7 election.

NZ-POLITICS · BLOOMBERG

Opportunity Party emerges as rival kingmaker to Peters in NZ race

Bloomberg reports a political outsider evoking former prime minister Jacinda Ardern could determine who forms New Zealand's next government, as the Opportunity Party vies with **Winston Peters** for kingmaker status nine days before the vote.

NZ-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Mongrel Mob photos with MPs become a flashpoint in New Zealand's election

Photos of Te Pāti Māori and Green Party MPs meeting Mongrel Mob members at an Auckland gang pad have forced parties across New Zealand's political spectrum to respond, with National and Labour both criticising the minor parties over the encounter ahead of the November 7 election.

CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

One Nation rejects $200,000 staffer, accuses Albanese of meddling

Pauline Hanson accused **Anthony Albanese** of trying to divide One Nation after MP **David Farley** rejected an unsolicited offer of an extra $200,000 staffer, the latest flashpoint in a dispute over the prime minister's power to set parliamentary staffing levels. Hanson called the system 'grubby' and wants an independent body to set staffing instead.

AU-POLITICS · GUARDIAN AUSTRALIA

Albanese concedes savings needed as Labor faces cost-of-living pressure

Anthony Albanese ruled out major cuts to health, education and essential services in December's mid-year budget update but conceded savings are required as Labor struggles to curb inflation, the Guardian reported, accusing the Coalition of hypocrisy for not backing existing savings measures.

AU-DEFENSE · ABC NEWS

Defence official sought minister's help to keep evidence off social media

A Defence official asked the minister for support in keeping evidence off social media, ABC News reported, raising fresh questions about transparency within the department amid ongoing parliamentary scrutiny of military accountability.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Burke queries sentencing as court weighs control order for ISIS-linked man

Home Affairs Minister **Tony Burke** questioned sentencing outcomes as a court considered a control order for a man linked to the alleged Bondi attacker, The Australian reported, amid wider debate over counter-terrorism sentencing settings.

BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

REUTERS

RBNZ governor says chances of December rate hike are 'high'

New Zealand's central bank governor said the chances of a December Official Cash Rate hike are 'high,' Reuters reported, a potential shift that would land weeks after the November 7 general election.

REUTERS

ASIC talks to bankers over failed $5 billion Firmus IPO

Australia's corporate regulator is in discussions with bankers involved in the collapsed *$5 billion* Firmus initial public offering, Reuters reported, as scrutiny grows over disclosures made ahead of the failed listing.

ABC NEWS

Regulator flags 'continued non-compliance' at Santos's Barossa gas project

Australia's offshore petroleum regulator told Santos it holds concerns about fuel use and gas flaring at the multi-billion-dollar Barossa project, citing 'continued non-compliance' after onshore and offshore inspections, a leaked letter obtained by ABC News shows.

PRIMARY DOCUMENTS

READOUT · NZ MINISTERIAL

New Zealand opens new detector dog facility in Tonga

New Zealand's government announced the opening of a new detector dog facility in Tonga, according to a release on the Beehive government website, part of ongoing border security capacity-building with Pacific partners.

UPCOMING

NOV 7

New Zealand general election

Polling shows National below 25 percent and the Opportunity Party emerging as a potential kingmaker, raising the prospect of a Labour-Greens coalition government.

NOV 2026

RBA interest rate decision

ABC reporting flags a rate rise as 'all-but-confirmed' after September inflation hit 4.3 percent, the highest reading since March.

DEC 2026

RBNZ Official Cash Rate decision

The governor says the chances of a hike are 'high,' which would land weeks after the general election and shape the incoming government's fiscal room.

FEB 2027

Fiji general election

Islands Business reports the vote is 'in limbo' with no Writ of Election yet issued, amid a parallel push for a constitutional referendum and calls to defer it six months.

THE WIRE

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

LOWY INTERPRETER

Colombo Port: a Chinese exit gives Australia a renewed chance

Lowy Institute's Interpreter argues Australia's lasting advantage in the Indian Ocean will come from building institutions rather than simply replacing Chinese investors at Colombo Port.

AUKUS

LOWY INTERPRETER

Lowy: Australia's $30 billion AUKUS-era base boom needs scrutiny

New satellite imagery analysed by the Lowy Institute shows how quickly four Australian bases are being rebuilt for the AUKUS era, with the Interpreter arguing the *$30 billion* program needs more public scrutiny.

CHINA-PACIFIC

ASPI STRATEGIST

ASPI Fault Lines tracks Taiwan drones, Timor deals and New Caledonia diplomacy

ASPI's fortnightly Fault Lines roundup covers regional security developments from October 16 to 29, including Taiwanese drone activity, Timorese defence deals and New Caledonian diplomacy shaping the Indo-Pacific order.

PACIFIC-POLITICS

DEVPOLICY BLOG

Devpolicy: Fiji's first referendum rests on a one-vote margin

Devpolicy Blog reports Fiji's path to its first referendum rests on a one-vote margin, a contested counting rule and campaign regulations yet to be written, with the clock ticking toward the vote.

FIJIVILLAGE

Fiji launches new Cyber Security Incident Reporting Portal

Fiji has launched a Cyber Security Incident Reporting Portal alongside two other initiatives, Fijivillage reported, part of a broader push to strengthen the country's digital security infrastructure.

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

PNG POST-COURIER

PNGDF officer calls multinational air exercise a valuable lesson

A Papua New Guinea Defence Force officer said Exercise Kapa Pisin provided valuable lessons for future operations despite the challenges of coordinating a complex multinational air exercise, the Post-Courier reported.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

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↑ BACK TO TOP

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